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14th WEEK



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GS II ... Effect of Policies and Politics of Developed and Developing Countries on India's Interests.

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Big thaw on the Korean peninsula

The crucial unknown in the high-stakes diplomacy is Donald Trump's idea of what an acceptable 'deal' is



RAKESH SOOD

An unusual charm offensive is under way on the Korean peninsula and the unlikely architect is none other than the North Korean Supreme Leader, Kim Jong-un. During the last three months, he has played a deft political hand, a far cry from his rhetorical exchanges with U.S. President Donald Trump. Last year, Mr. Trump was threatening the "Rocket Man" with "fire and fury like the world has never seen"; the North Korean leader described him as a "dotard" and his military called his statement "as a load of nonsense". Now the two leaders are planning a summit in May which according to Mr. Trump could lead to "the greatest deal in the world".

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tions between the two countries have soured since 2013 when Jang Song Thaek, Mr. Kim's uncle who was responsible for managing the China relationship, was purged. Missile tests when China was hosting the G20 summit in 2016 and the Belt and Road Forum in 2017 together with a nuclear test during the BRICS summit in 2017 were embarrassments for China. As sanctions tightened under successive UN Security Council resolutions, North Korea blamed China for 'dancing to the tune' of the U.S.

However Mr. Kim realises that he needs help to handle U.S. pressure. His China visit acknowledges Mr. Xi's extension in power beyond 2022; and for China, it reflects its pivotal role in any negotiations regarding North Korea. Mr. Xi has sent a personal message to Mr. Trump about his meeting with Mr. Kim while Politburo member Yang Jiechi is being despatched to Seoul. In Washington, recent appointments of John Bolton as National Security Adviser and Mike Pompeo as Secretary of State, both hardliners, raise the stakes for North Korea.

Reconciling objectives

Mr. Kim's objectives are clear – securing regime legitimacy, regime security and sanctions relief. A summit with Mr. Trump provides legitimacy as long as it begins a dialogue process leading towards diplomatic recognition. In 1992, despite North Korean reservations, China recognised South Korea and today it is one of the South's largest partners and a major investment source. How South Korea and the U.S. deal with the move towards recognition will demand political creativity.

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South Korea would like to ensure that it has a veto over U.S. decisions regarding North Korea and gaining operational control over its own military forces, both of which will require protracted negotiations. Meanwhile, Mr. Moon will do his utmost to maintain credibility in Washington and Pyongyang to keep his 'sunshine policy' on track. In Europe, the two Germanys recognised each other in 1972 (the U.S. recognised East Germany in 1974) as part of Willy Brandt's 'ostpolitik', long before German unification was achieved in 1990.

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The big unknown is Mr. Trump's idea of what is an acceptable 'deal'. Will a process towards eventual denuclearisation tempt him or will he reject it as 'fake news' and revert to relying on sanctions and military pressure as some of his advisers are inclined to? Major compromises will be needed for reconciling interests of all the key players for the high stakes summit on the Korean peninsula to succeed.

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4 Big thaw on the Korean peninsula

The crucial unknown in the high-stakes diplomacy is Donald Trump's idea of what an acceptable 'deal' is. An unusual charm offensive is under way on the Korean peninsula and the unlikely architect is none other than the North Korean Supreme Leader, Kim Jong-un. During the last three months, he has played a deft political hand, a far cry from his rhetorical exchanges with U.S. President Donald Trump. Last year, Mr. Trump was threatening the "Rocket Man" with "fire and fury like the world has never seen"; the North Korean leader described him as a "dotard" and his military called his statement "as a load of nonsense". Now the two leaders are planning a summit in May which according to Mr. Trump could lead to "the greatest deal in the world". Since 2011 when Mr. Kim took over, North Korea has conducted four nuclear tests; the first two were conducted in 2006 and 2009. The sixth test, last September, had a yield more than six times the Hiroshima bomb. He has accelerated the missile programme, conducting nearly 80 tests, compared to an estimated 16 by his father Kim Jong-il between 1994 and 2011.

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KIM JONG-UN

Supreme Leader, North Korea



KIM JONG-UN AND NORTH KOREA

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- 2 The first two were conducted in 2006 and 2009.
- 3 The 6th test had a yield more than 6 times the Hiroshima bomb.
- 4 He accelerated the missile programme. He conducted nearly 80 tests, compared to 16 by his father, Kim Jong-il between 1994 and 2011.

MONGOLIA

NORTH KOREA

SOUTH KOREA

CHINA

Yellow Sea

East China Sea

Sea of Japan

North Pacific Ocean

JAPAN



THE SEQUENCE OF EVENTS SINCE JANUARY, 2018

- 1 Participation of the North Korean team in the Winter Olympics as well as two Korean teams marching together
- 2 South Korean delegation led by National Security Adviser and Intelligence Chief visited Pyongyang to explore the idea of talks.
- 3 Now, the summit is planned on April 27 at the Peace House



JIMMY CARTER

Former President, US



BILL CLINTON

Former President, US

WHAT ABOUT USA?

- 1** Two South Korean officials travelled to Washington to brief Donald Trump. Subsequently Mr. Trump had agreed to a summit with North Korean leader in May
- 2** This will be first summit meeting between USA and North Korea.
- 3** Jimmy Carter and Bill Clinton travelled to Pyongyang in 1994 and 2009, but after their terms as US President ended.

Now, the summit is planned between US and North Korea in May.



WHAT ABOUT CHINA?

- 1 North Korean leader travelled by train to Beijing on March 25. It is Kim's first foreign trip since he took over in 2011.
- 2 He stated that South Korea and US responded with goodwill. He can think of denuclearisation of peninsula reaching resolution.



WHY CHINA IS MORE IMPORTANT FOR NORTH KOREA?

- 1 China is North Korea's political ally and economic lifeline
- 2 China accounts for 90 % of North Korea's foreign trade
- 3 It resisted tightening of sanctions that could lead to collapse of the regime, but in recent times the relations have been soured. In between North Korea blamed China for "dancing to the tunes" of US.

But, Kim now, realized that he needs helping hand to handle US pressure and China's visit, now, assumed significance because Xi Jinping power may go beyond 2022 also.



WHAT IS REQUIRED FOR KIM AT THIS JUNCTURE?

- Regime legitimacy
- Regime Security
- Sanctions Relief

In 1992, despite North Korean reservations, China recognized South Korea and today, it is one of the South's largest partners and major investment source.



DENUCLEARISATION OF PENINSULA, IS IT POSSIBLE?

Probably, it may be a long-drawn out process

- Discussions regarding the US nuclear umbrella for South Korea.
- Presence of 23,500 American troops in South Korea.
- Converting the 1953 armistice into peace treaty, which will guarantee regime security.

All will depend on above aspects.



WHY US PROVIDED THAAD MISSILE DEFENCE SYSTEM?

- 1 Aggressive testing by North Korea resulted in the deployment of THAAD Missile Defence System. It aggravated Chinese concerns.
- 2 China would prefer lowering the tensions and moreover, it is in no hurry to see Korean unification



*A lot depends on
the magnanimity
shown by both
USA and China.*

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